

Music & Movement Activities

A Publication of the Environments Professional Group

Why Are Children Playing?

For the young child, play and work involve the same actions: interacting with people, manipulating objects, and making discoveries that help make sense of the world. Learning happens naturally through play. Play is the work of children. For school success, children must develop physically, mentally, emotionally, socially, and creatively. Play is a crucial part of this development of the whole child.

What Are Music & Movement Activities?

Young children are active, creative, and spontaneous. They need to sing, to listen to music, to make satisfying sounds with simple musical instruments, and to use their bodies in rhythmic response to music. Song, dance, and musical instruments bring joy to children's play. The music and movement area in the classroom contains tapes, CD's, equipment for listening to music, rhythm instruments, and a variety of props such as scarves to encourage movement and creative dance.

What Are Children Learning?

Young children enjoy music and movement activities and often use them to express feelings and emotions, relieving stress and increasing self-esteem. Listening and moving to the beat of a lively CD is a positive way for active young children to release energy and work out frustrations. Swaying gently to soft sounds can help calm busy children and transition them to quieter activities.

Growth taking place in the music and movement center includes social development. Dancing and singing together help children form bonds and build friendships. Young children playing musical games and engaging in movement activities learn to take turns and to cooperate with each other.

Physical (large and fine motor) development is enhanced with music and movement activities. When children spin, balance, skip, jump, hop, and dance, they are exercising and gaining control of large muscles. When they sing and do fingerplays, they are learning to control hand and finger muscles. Using musical instruments increases the coordination of large and small arm and hand muscles.

Listening skills, auditory discrimination, and concentration are all promoted through music and movement. With play that involves activity CD's, songs, and musical games, young children practice listening, paying attention, and following directions.

Music helps children develop memory as well as language and literacy skills.

Young children who love word play are intrigued by the rhythm and rhyme of song lyrics. Children will naturally memorize favorite songs. Literacy skills expand effortlessly when children change words or make up new verses for familiar songs.

Multicultural awareness and acceptance of other people are encouraged when music from many cultures is shared with young children. They learn to appreciate the sounds of other ethnic groups and to understand that, just like them, children everywhere enjoy songs and musical games.

Music is a fun tool to use for integrated curriculum topics. Songs about animals, transportation, and other themes reinforce the learning that is happening in other centers. Singing about colors, numbers, and shapes helps build basic concepts informally.

What Can You Do to Encourage Children's Learning?

- Provide children with a music center indoors that has enough room to sing, dance, and move freely without interfering with others. An area that may function both as an indoor active play space and as a circle time area is often chosen. A good floor covering is a short-napped carpet that provides a comfortable place for sitting and that can also be used for dance and movement activities.
- Equip the music and movement center with a CD and/or cassette player. Have available CD's or cassettes of all kinds of music – classical, folk, country, blues, activity songs for children, music from other lands, etc. Make sure these include music that uses a variety of instruments and has differing tempos. Choose music for children selectively. Music made especially for children should be just as pleasant and enjoyable to listen to as music for adults.
- Providing instruments for children to play allows hands-on creative musical explorations. Choose those that are safe and appropriate for the age of the children using them. Include instruments that make a variety of sounds and that use different movements. Instruments should be sturdily constructed to stand up to the active play of young children. Most instruments will be rhythm or percussion instruments since these are the easiest for young children to use. It is best to avoid those that require blowing or mouthing for sanitation reasons. Scarves, hats, parachutes, bean bags, and other movement accessories add to the fun and increase the variety of experiences possible.
- Sharing music with young children should be a relaxed fun time. Music time in toddler and preschool classrooms is a musical experience rather than music education. Allowing young children to feel free to express themselves through music and movement without fear of failure helps to develop positive self-concepts.
- Introduce musical activities that are appropriate for the age of the children. Young toddlers like moving to the beat of music as they “dance.” Join in the fun, and they may try to copy your movements. Older toddlers and young preschool age children enjoy simple musical group games like “Ring-around-the-Rosie.” Older young children may be ready for more involved activities like “The Hokey Pokey.” These types of

experiences enhance physical coordination and social cooperation while they give practice with sequence and following directions.

- Use songs and movement activities as fun informal learning tools. Traditional children's fingerplay songs like "Three Little Ducks" reinforce math and number concepts. Favorites like "The Wheels on the Bus" expand descriptive vocabularies. Moving like animals, snowflakes, or falling leaves to music increases scientific observational skills and knowledge of the natural world.
- Singing stimulates language and literacy growth. Sharing activities that involve clapping or using rhythm instruments as children sing their names or other words helps children hear syllables and understand the structure of words. When they sing, children gain knowledge of syntax as they experience the patterns of phrases and sentences in songs.
- As with any activity, remember to follow the lead of the children. When they tire or interest drops, it is time to stop. If enjoyment is high, it may be appropriate to extend the music play longer.
- Musical activities need not always be teacher directed. Make instruments and movement props like scarves available to give children the opportunity to enjoy music independently. Teach children to be considerate of others. Help them learn to use the instruments in a designated space and in a way that won't interfere with others.
- Soft music played at meal and nap times may help calm children. Use background music judiciously, however. Music that is played constantly can become overly stimulating. The noise level may rise as everyone tries to be heard over the music.
- By providing positive musical experiences, adults help young children develop motor skills and cognitive knowledge. Appropriate music and movement experiences can enhance language skills, social interactions, and self-esteem in children.

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The Environments Professional Group is a team of educators and designers who come together to make the connection between the needs of early childhood programs and the developmentally appropriate products that meet these needs.

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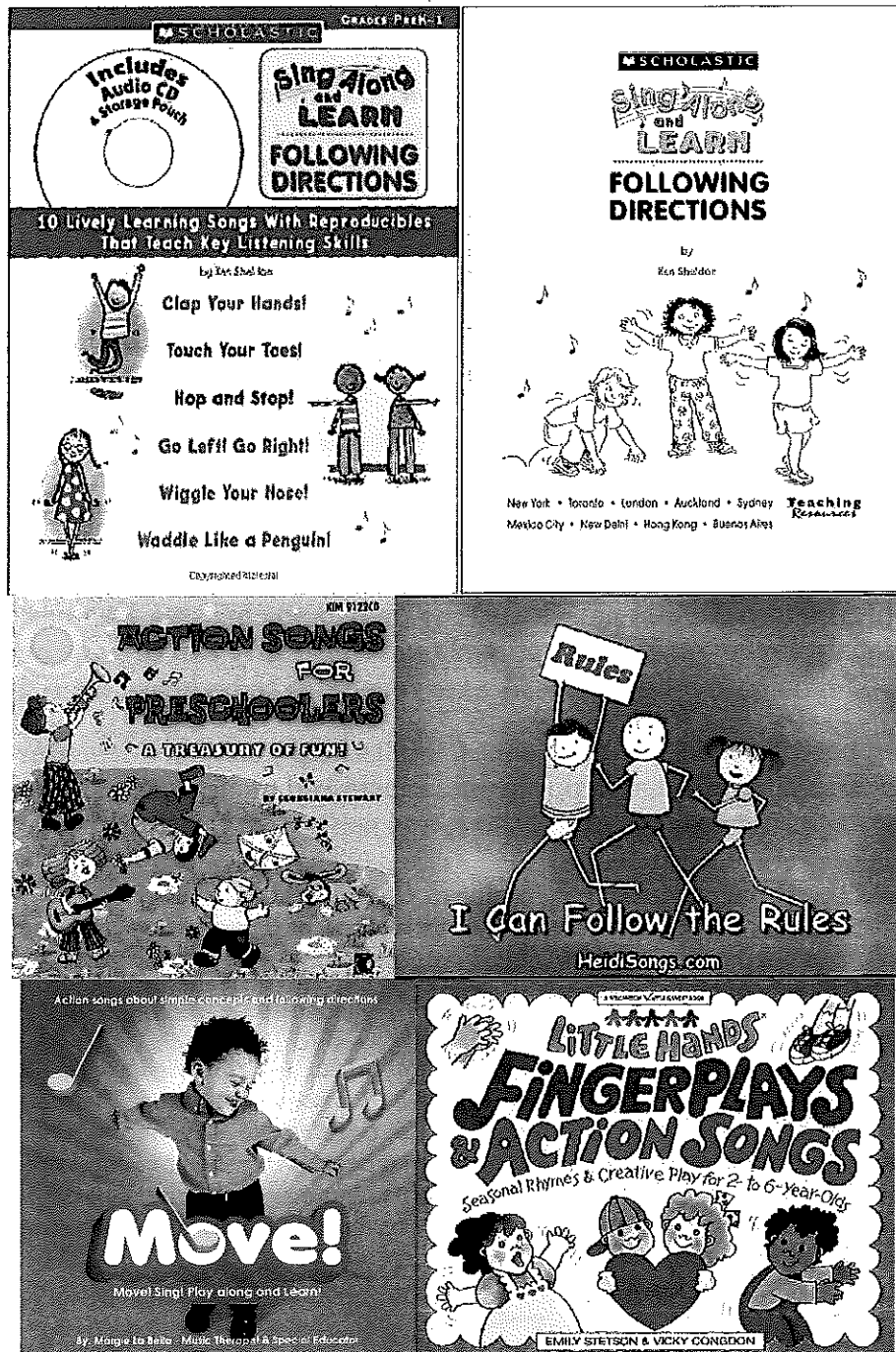
These suggestions and guidelines are general in nature and are not intended to take the place of any specific instructions provided to you by your supervisors or regulatory agencies. In addition, appropriate caution, reasonable safety precautions, and adult supervision of children are recommended at all times. Do not leave children unattended at any time.

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Sing Along and Learn: Following Directions



6 Apps to Help Get Kids Kindergarten Ready

From math basics to learning how to follow directions, these 6 apps will help your preschooler learn important skills for entering kindergarten

1. Cookie Monster's Challenge

Cookie Monster is the star of the show in this highly interactive app for 3-5 year olds. Each game your child plays is accompanied by verbal instructions by Cookie Monster, asking his helper to tap, swipe and more. Mini-games test memory skills, self-control, listening and problem solving, all with the playful energy you'd expect from the furry blue monster.

As your child follows directions, they unlock increasing levels of challenges to help Cookie reach his final goal. (A cookie, of course!)

iPad, Android, \$2.99

2. Domi Domi Blocks

Creating patterns and practicing logical thinking are all part of the game in Domi Domi Blocks. As your kids match the color pattern they see on the left, they're honing those fine motor skills, concentration, and memory with increasing levels of difficulty. But your kids will be having too much fun with the game's cute creatures, cheerful music, and hidden surprises to notice.

iPad/iPhone, Android, \$2.99

3. Endless Numbers

Quirky characters excited to play with numbers will spread that enthusiasm to your kids as they tap and swipe their way through Endless Numbers. The app grows from teaching preschoolers to recognize numbers to simple math equations your kindergartener can practice all school year long.

The app is free to download with two packs available to purchase to unlock numbers up to 100.

iPhone/iPad, Android, Free

4. Hip Hop Hen ABC Letter Tracing

With activities that focus on pre-writing, phonics and letter tracing skills, Hip Hop Hen ABC Letter Tracing is ideal for growing with kids as they start with simple coloring of letters and work up to practicing writing phrases and cursive letters.

Fine motor skills are put to the test as preschoolers and kindergarteners use the intuitive app to form letters by following an adorable hen across the dotted lines.

iPhone/iPad, \$2.99

5. Lazoo Art Box

There are a lot of excellent apps out there that inspire preschoolers to express their creativity, but Lazoo Art Box also focuses on following directions and early literacy — skills that any kindergartener could use a little practice with.

Kids are encouraged to color and draw on pictures with specific directions. As the suggestions for each illustration are read aloud, they are highlighted word by word to help budding readers recognize words. Then comes the exciting part for the little artist: watching their creations come to animated life once they're done!

iPhone/iPad, \$1.99

6. YouTube Kids

Designed for kids 3-5, YouTube Kids presents curated videos and channels for preschoolers curious about the world. They'll love using the voice-activated search and looking through the recommended videos featuring science, languages, some of their favorite TV characters, and more. You'll love not worrying about inappropriate content and setting a time limit so that the app is used in moderation.

While the app is free, many videos are accompanied by multiple advertisements.

iPhone/iPad, Android, Free